INDIA TODAY RPG Happiness Quest 2



PATH-SHALA
An evening of study at the 'abhyas galli' off the busy Worli Naka in Mumbai

MANDAR DEODHAR

Down Study Lane

A small alleyway in Mumbai has shaped the careers of thousands of students for decades now, offering them a quiet, undisturbed refuge to study

By **DHAVAL KULKARNI**

Every evening, Sudhir Suhas Adelkar, a resident of the BDD chawls in Mumbai, heads with his books to a narrow lane in Worli located behind the R.A. Podar Ayurved Medical College building. By the time he reaches the Sudam Kalu Ahire road, many other youngsters are already there, each occupying small portions of the tree-lined pavement. Hailing from various parts of the city, these children, mostly from chawls, slums and thousands of lower-income families that populate the city, gather here for a sincere undertaking: studying. In a space-starved metropolis like Mumbai, the 'abhyas galli' (study lane) is the only dedicated place for them to study—a luxury they can't find in the matchbox houses they share with their families, nor in the noisy neighbourhoods they come from. They stay till wee hours of the night, discussing with their peers various topics, exchanging notes, or just reading by themselves. Over decades, from this very street have risen lawyers, doctors or police officers. Adelkar, who comes from a tiny 180 sq. ft house, has been studying here since Class 8. "Now, I'm preparing for the Maharashtra Public Service Commission exams. There is no space at my home. This is a quiet place for me to study," says Adelkar.

Locals say that the history of 'abhyas galli' goes back at least three to four generations. D.V. Pawar, principal of the Kirti M. Doongursee College of Arts, Science and Commerce, recalls studying here after he came to Mumbai from Bhor in Pune district as a child. "I used to stay in the police lines in the BDD chawls as my elder brother was in the police force. Ours was a joint family and the house was just 10x10 ft, which made it difficult for me to study. Hence, I used to study at the lane." Pawar graduated from college in 1981, and he later joined it to teach economics and rural development. Then there's Abhijit Patil, a Worli resident and leader of the Yuva Sena, the youth wing of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray), who says that even his grandfather frequented 'abhyas galli' as a child.

Though students can be found studying here round the clock, the numbers rise after dusk. The road sees a gradual drop in footfall and traffic after midnight, ensuring that the youngsters can study till early morning, when Mumbai wakes up and the daily humdrum begins. While many of them come from nearby chawl clusters, a few also come from areas as far as Chembur. Nikhil Nilesh Thakur, who lives in Worli Koliwada,